

The warning signs across the attacks that target people, and the one move that beats them.

62%

of breaches involve the human element

Verizon DBIR 2026

\$3.05B

reported losses to business email compromise in 2025

FBI IC3 2025

21 sec

median time to click a phishing link

Verizon DBIR 2024

EMAIL AND MESSAGE LURES (PHISHING)

- 01

Urgency and pressure

Act now, this expires, do not tell anyone. Real requests survive a pause.
- 02

A sender that almost matches

Look-alike domains, a reply-to that differs, a display name that spoofs someone you know.
- 03

Verify your account links

A login page reached from a message, not from your own bookmark or typed address.

PHONE AND VOICE (VISHING)

- 04

A call that manufactures urgency

IT, a bank, or a manager who needs you to act before you have time to think.
- 05

Requests to read a code aloud

No legitimate caller ever needs the one-time code on your screen.
- 06

Pressure not to hang up and check

Discouraging a callback is the tell. Hang up and call a known number.

IMPERSONATION AND DEEPPAKES

- 07

A familiar face or voice pushing a transfer

A senior leader on video asking for an urgent, secret payment or login.
- 08

Audio and video that drift

Lip-sync that lags, odd blinking, flat lighting, or a voice slightly off.
- 09

Camera or mic problems on cue

Quality drops the moment you ask a hard or unexpected question.

AUTHENTICATION ATTACKS (MFA AND AITM)

- 10

An MFA prompt you did not start

Approving a push you did not request hands your live session to the attacker.
- 11

A login reached through a link

Adversary-in-the-middle pages relay your real login and steal the session token.

PAYMENT AND AUTHORITY

- 12

New payment details by message

Wire changes, gift cards, crypto, or new bank details that arrive in a message or call.
- 13

Requests to bypass process

Just this once, skip the second approver, keep it quiet.
- 14

Authority used to skip the check

A name, a title, or a logo deployed to make you waive the normal step.

DO / DON'T

- DO

- Slow down. Pressure is the attack. A real request survives you taking five minutes to check.
 - Verify on a channel you chose: a typed address, a saved bookmark, or a number off your card.
 - Call the person back on a number you already have, not one from the message.
 - Use phishing-resistant MFA (an app, a passkey, or a security key) on important accounts.
 - Require a second person to approve any new or changed payment.
- DON'T

- Do not click a login link from an email, text, or DM. Open the site yourself.
 - Do not read a one-time code aloud or type it into a page you reached from a message.
 - Do not approve an MFA prompt you did not personally start.
 - Do not let urgency, authority, or secrecy talk you out of your normal checks.
 - Do not act on a new payment instruction without an out-of-band callback.

THE ONE MOVE

The one move that beats most of them: stop and verify on a channel you chose. Call back on a known number, open the site from your own bookmark, confirm with the person directly. The attacker is counting on you not to pause.

IF IT HAPPENS

- 1

Stop. Do not send anything else and do not click further.
- 2

If you ran an attachment or gave remote access, disconnect that device from the network.
- 3

From a clean device, change the password and sign out all sessions on any exposed account.
- 4

Tell your bank or IT immediately. With wire fraud, the first hours matter most.
- 5

Report it: in the US, reportfraud.ftc.gov and the FBI at ic3.gov.

Sources: Verizon Data Breach Investigations Report (2024, 2026); FBI IC3 2025 Annual Report. Figures as publicly reported.

How this is made: threat level: human is an AI-assisted production. A real person researches every story, checks each claim against primary sources, and is accountable for the facts.